



NPTEL ONLINE CERTIFICATION COURSES

Employment Communication **- A Lab based course**

Dr Seema Singh
Department of Humanities & Social Sciences
IIT Kharagpur

Lecture 26 : Group Discussions
Module VI: LAB (Practice Session) 1

LAB Practice Sessions & Feedback

CONCEPTS COVERED

Module VI: Group Discussions (GDs)

Practice Sessions 1 to 4

Four GDs of 10 Minutes (approx) duration
with 7-8 Group Discussants (in each GD session)
followed by Feedback



Three types of GDs

1. Traditional GDs
2. Case Study GDs
3. Fishbowl GDs

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Introduction

- Employers view effective communication as critical to an individual's success in today's competitive workplace.
- Activity designed to provide specific help in developing interpersonal communication and discussion skills critical to success in business and society (McPherson, 2005)

Introduction (contd.)

This activity helps students identify and practice effective interpersonal behaviors in a professional context while exploring relevant issues confronting managers and businesses today.



Introduction (contd.)

- Activity uses a “fishbowl” discussion, a term derived from the format of the discussion.
- Active participants are surrounded by observers (similar to fish in a fishbowl) who listen to and evaluate the dynamics of the smaller group (Dutt, 1997; Hensley, 2002; Silberman & Hansburg, 2004), as shown in Figure 1.

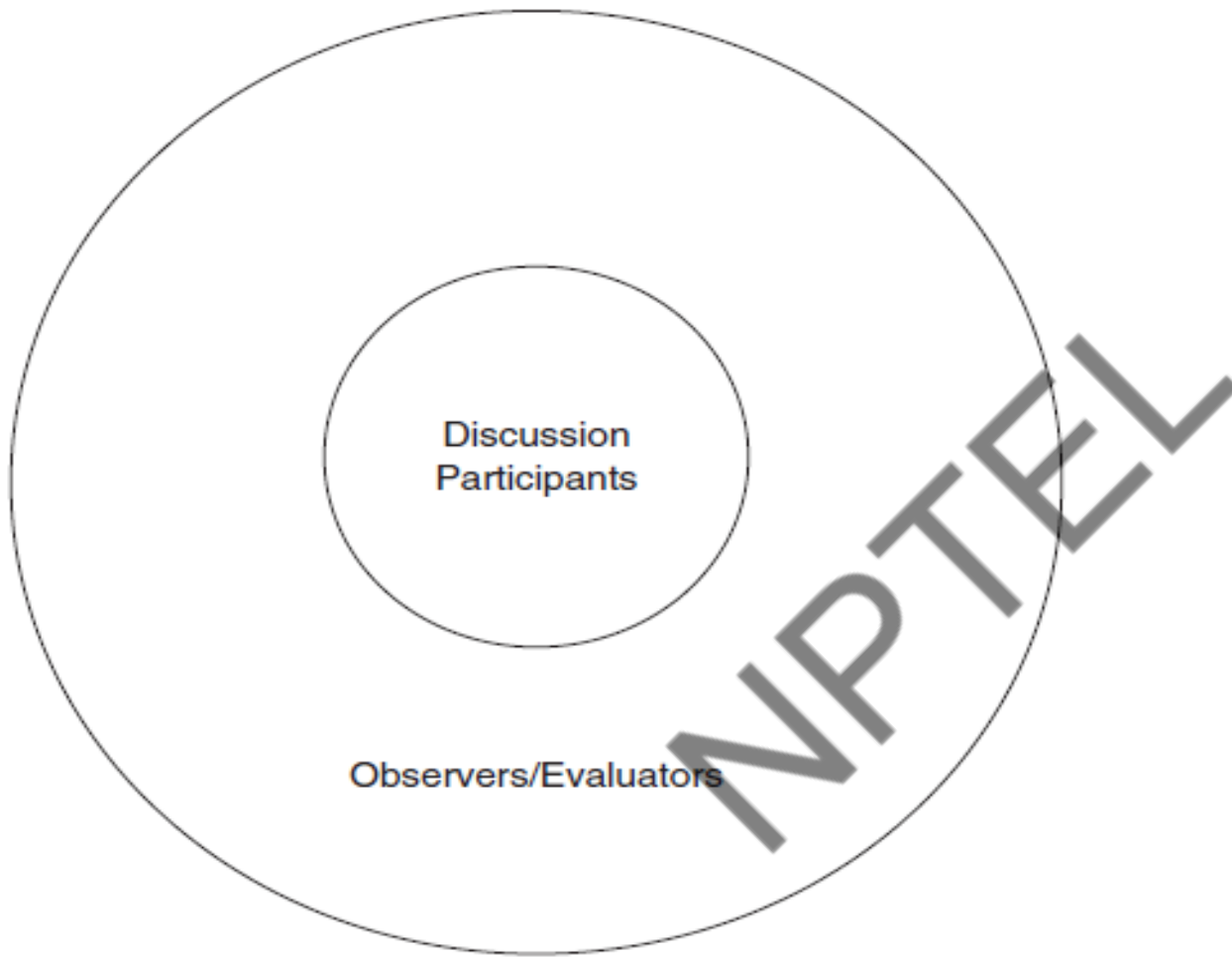


Figure 1. Model of Fishbowl Discussion

Rationale

Activity has value for several reasons:

- Evaluators consider not only the content discussed but also the communication activities that help or hinder discussion.
- Structure provides a systematic way to identify, examine, and teach specific interpersonal communication behaviors.
- Activity provides an opportunity for an entire class to participate by requiring students to either participate in a discussion or evaluate one.

Rationale (contd.)

- Activity pushes students to conduct research and form opinions on topics relevant to the course as well as their future professional life.
- The focus shifts from the teacher to the students - a significant method for promoting deeper learning among students (Anderson & Soden 2001; Kjellin & Stenfors, 2003).

Procedure

- Typical class of about 30, divided into groups of 7 or 8.
- Determine the topic students will research and discuss.
- Instructor directs students to consider issues in a professional context.

Procedure (contd.)

- Topics:** Discrimination or harassment in the workplace, women and the “glass ceiling,” affirmative action, ethical decision making and corporate responsibility, consumer or employee privacy, and other topics related to current issues and news.
- **Individuals work independently to conduct research in preparation for the discussion.**

Procedure (contd.)

- The group meets together to create a list of 8 to 10 key questions the group thinks ought to be posed or addressed during the discussion.
- Students can rank the questions and address them in order of importance.
- Students should turn in the final list of questions the class session prior to the group's discussion to make certain adequate preparations occur.

Procedure (contd.)

- Before the actual discussions take place, the instructor spends time in class reviewing behaviors and actions that either help or hinder meaningful group communication (Refer Table 1).
- Students can be encouraged to evaluate the relative harm or merit of the behaviors.

Procedure (contd.)

Table 1. Positive and Negative Discussion Behaviors

Positive Discussion Behaviors

Taking a position on an issue
Providing a relevant comment
Supporting a position with evidence
Bringing others into the discussion
Asking a clarifying question
Representing an opposing viewpoint
Demonstrating active listening

Negative Discussion Behaviors

Distracting others
Not paying attention
Interrupting others
Asking unnecessary/irrelevant questions
Monopolizing the discussion
Attacking another person personally

Procedure (contd.)

From the discussion of negative and positive behavior/s, the instructor creates an evaluation form and informs students that they will be scored by others in the class for their positive and negative behaviors during the fishbowl discussion (Figure 2).

Fishbowl Discussion Evaluation Sheet			
Put tally marks by + or – behaviors. After the discussion, multiply the number of marks by the value to determine the score for each behavior; then figure the total points.			
Positive Behaviors	Tally	Score	Comments
Taking a position on an issue (+2)			
Providing a relevant comment (+1)			
Supporting position with evidence/facts (+2)			
Bringing another person into discussion (+1)			
Asking a clarifying question (+1)			
Representing an opposing view (+2)			
Demonstrating active listening (+2)			
Negative Behaviors	Tally	Score	Comments
Distracting others/not paying attention (–2)			
Interrupting others (–2)			
Making unnecessary/irrelevant comments (–2)			
Monopolizing the discussion (–3)			
Attacking another person or position (–3)			
Total Points			

Figure 2. Sample Fishbowl Discussion Evaluation Sheet

Procedure (contd.)

- Individual evaluation sheet for each student can be used to provide feedback from the instructor and observing students.
- Group evaluation form can be created to track discussion behaviors of the entire group during the actual discussion (Figure 3).

	Discussion Members (put tally marks by + or – behaviors)							
	1.		2.		3.		4.	
Positive Behaviors	Tally Score		Tally Score		Tally Score		Tally Score	
Takes a position on an issue (+2)								
Provides a relevant comment (+1)								
Supports position w/evidence (+2)								
Brings another into discussion (+1)								
Asks a clarifying question (+1)								
Represents an opposing view (+2)								
Demonstrating active listening (+2)								
Negative Behaviors	Tally Score		Tally Score		Tally Score		Tally Score	
Distracts others/lacks attention (–2)								
Interrupts others (–2)								
Makes irrelevant comments (–2)								
Monopolizes the discussion (–3)								
Attacks another person (–3)								
Total Points								

Figure 3. Sample Group Fishbowl Discussion Evaluation Form

Procedure (contd.)

- Once students understand the criteria and are familiar with the evaluation forms, the instructor schedules specific dates for the fish-bowl discussions.
- Typically, the actual discussions take approximately 20 to 25 minutes, so two to three groups can present in a single class period, depending upon the length of the class.

Procedure (contd.)

- Groups select a member of the group to serve as a facilitator.
- The facilitator starts with a brief introduction (no longer than 2 minutes) of the topic and the purpose of the fishbowl discussion.
- Facilitator may also assume the role of keeping the dialogue moving if conversation wanes.
- In the final few minutes, the instructor lets the group know that the time is up and that each person will have 30 seconds to give a final statement about his / her position or feelings about the topic discussed.

Procedure (contd.)

- Facilitator makes final comments, observations, and recommendations within the organizational context.
- During the discussion, the other members of the class serve in an observation/evaluation role, making notes and scoring the conversation and interactions using the evaluation form created.
- At the conclusion of the discussion, the instructor asks members of the fishbowl what they felt went well and if there is anything they would work to improve if they did the activity again.

Procedure (contd.)

Evaluators may also:

- ask additional questions of the participants who have become the subject matter experts on their assigned topic.
- provide brief feedback, focusing on some of the strengths and weaknesses observed during the discussion.

Procedure (contd.)

- The follow-up conversation provides an opportunity to reemphasize and reinforce those behaviors that help and hinder interpersonal interactions and discussion.

Conclusion

- Activity described provides an alternative to traditional communication activities often assigned in business communication classes, focusing on verbal skills critical to students' success.
- In addition to being competent presenters, students need effective interpersonal, discussion, and conversation skills for the workplace.

Conclusion (contd.)

- Those adept with these skills are more apt to be hired and are more successful once they are on the job (McShulskis, 1996; Zorn & Violanti, 1996).
- Additionally, the activity provides students with an opportunity to research a topic, form an opinion, present evidence, and listen actively, all within a professional context.

References

Lecture nos. 24 & 25
from the current NPTEL course on
Employment Communication – A Lab based Course



References

- Anderson, T., & Soden, R. (2001). Peer interaction and the learning of critical thinking skills. *Psychology Learning and Teaching, 1*, 37-40.
- Dutt, K. M. (1997). The fishbowl motivates students to participate. *College Teaching, 45*, 143-148.
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- McPherson, K. (2005). *Building discussion skills for a civil society*. Retrieved January 26, 2006, from <http://www.peacejamnw.org/discoursecurriculum.pdf>
- McShulskis, E. (1996). Communication skills most important for new grade. *HR Magazine*, 41, 16.



References

- Silberman, M., & Hansburg, F. (2004). *Three-stage fishbowl discussion*. Retrieved January 26, 2006, from http://www.activetraining.com/facil_consult/tool_fishbowl.htm
- Zorn, T. E., & Violanti, M. T. (1996). Communication abilities and individual achievement in organizations. *Management Communication Quarterly*, 10, 139-167.



Many Thanks and God bless

Ist year Participants

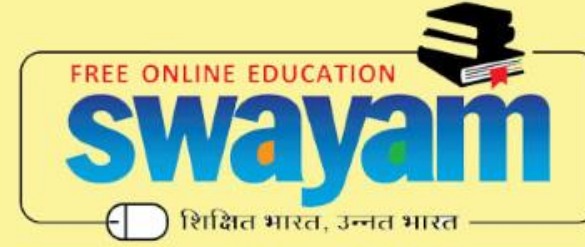
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Lecture 27 : Group Discussions
Module VI: LAB (Practice Session) 2

Now let's view TWO Group Discussions of the Case Study type....

Topics of the two CASE STUDY type of GDs:

1. New Products
2. Integration



Procedure (contd.)

- The follow-up conversation provides an opportunity to reemphasize and reinforce those behaviors that help and hinder interpersonal interactions and discussion.

Many Thanks and God bless

Ist year Participants

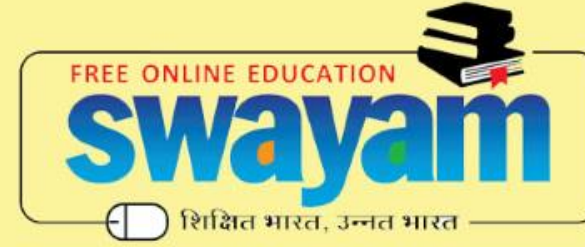
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Lecture 28 : Group Discussions
Module VI: LAB (Practice Session) 3

Now let's view the first of the Fishbowl type of Group Discussion...

Topic: The Head Office

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References

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Lecture 29 : Group Discussions
Module VI: LAB (Practice Session) 4

LAB Practice Sessions & Feedback

CONCEPTS COVERED

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Practice Sessions 1 to 4

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Procedure (contd.)

- The follow-up conversation provides an opportunity to reemphasize and reinforce those behaviors that help and hinder interpersonal interactions and discussion.

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Many Thanks and God bless

Ist year Participants

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Master of Human Resource Management (MHRM) Programme

Department of Humanities & Social Sciences

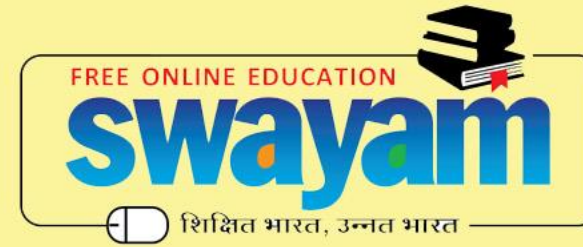
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Lecture 30: Interviewing for Employment

Interviewing: From both sides of the desk

CONCEPTS COVERED

- What is an Interview?
- How do you feel about Interviews?
Assessing your Interview anxiety
- The Hiring Interview
- Diversity and the Interview



CONCEPTS COVERED

Interviewing: From both sides of the desk

- Technology and the Job Search
- Looking at the law: Illegal questions in Interviews
- Increasing your effectiveness in Interviews: Guidelines
- Summary



What is an Interview?

- The nature of Interviews: Beyond conversation
 - *Interview* —most common type of purposeful, planned, decision-making, person-to-person communication

What is an Interview?

Types of Interviews: Purposes and goals

1. Information-gathering
2. Appraisal
3. Persuasive
4. Exit
5. Counseling
6. Hiring

Types of Interviews

(1 of 2)

1. **Information-gathering interview -designed to collect information,opinions or data**
2. **Appraisal interview - designed for evaluation purposes**
3. **Persuasive interview - designed to influence attitudes or behaviour**

Types of Interviews

(2 of 2)

4. Exit interview - designed to determine why someone is leaving a position
5. Counseling interview - designed to provide guidance
6. Hiring interview - designed to select the right person for a job

Examples of types of Interviews

(1 of 2)

1. Interviews conducted with Experts to complete an assignment, interviews conducted for the popular Media
2. Interviewer is a superior from management, expectations and behaviors are brought closer together
3. Salespeople with Customers

Examples of types of Interviews

(2 of 2)

4. Employee and employer, to refine the hiring process, to help prevent other employees from leaving, or merely to make the departure a more pleasant experience for both.
5. Conducted by someone trained in Psychology, to guide and support the interviewee.
6. Purpose of filling up an Employment position.

How do you feel about Interviews?

Assessing your Interview anxiety

- Not being concerned at all about participating in an interview is just as much of a problem as being a nervous wreck

The Hiring Interview

- Preliminary tasks: Preparing the Cover Letter and the Resume
 1. The Cover Letter
 2. The Resume

The Hiring Interview

The Resume

1. Contact Information
2. Job Objective
3. Employment History
4. Education
5. Relevant professional certifications and affiliations
6. Community service
7. Special skills and interests
8. References

Simple Cover Letter

1616 River Road
New Milford, NJ 07646
April 10, 2004

Ms. Kelly Ames
Vice President, Human Resources
Stars and Strategies
1850 Broadway
New York, NY 10023

Dear Ms. Ames:

Your advertisement for a client representative in sports management appearing in last Sunday's *New York Times* immediately caught my attention and piqued my interest. My education and training uniquely qualify me to assist you in taking Stars and Strategies to the next level.

According to your advertisement, the job includes "assisting in the coordination and implementation of client services, as well as assisting in the identification and opening of new markets." It occurs to me that my background and experience in sports marketing parallel your needs. In addition, I am a highly motivated individual and a self-starter, with the following special qualifications to offer:

Four years of formal training in marketing
and entrepreneurial studies
Proficiency in computers and Web site design

Once you have examined the enclosed résumé, I would like to talk with you about how I can put my skills and abilities to work for Stars and Strategies. I hope to have the opportunity to discuss in depth how my educational background and professional experience can contribute to your company's growth.

Sincerely,

John P. Garcia

John P. Garcia
Enclosure



Sample Resume

JOHN P. GARCIA

1616 River Road
New Milford, New Jersey 07646
201-836-4444
jpg@aol.com

EDUCATION

School of Management, Syracuse University
Bachelor of Science in Management, May 2001; GPA: 4.0
Concentration in Marketing and Entrepreneurial Studies

HONORS

Golden Key National Honor Society
Dean's List 1999-2004
President, Investment Club

EXPERIENCE

Steiner Sports Marketing, New York, New York
(Summer 1999, 2000) Marketing Intern
Assisted in the management of client relations
Solved client and customer problems
Represented the company at numerous special events

Shearson-Lehman Brothers, Stamford, Connecticut
(Summer 1998) Investment Intern
Assisted financial consultants
Analyzed trades
Evaluated financial securities options

KPM&G, Montvale, New Jersey
(Summer 1997) Accounting Intern
Assisted in analysis of weekly financial reports
Prepared daily cash activity records
Conducted interviews with clients to determine level of satisfaction

COMPUTER SKILLS

Proficient in HTML and Web site creation
Experienced in using Lotus, WordPerfect for Windows, Excel, PowerPoint, Quark Express, and PageMaker
Adept at mastering new programs and applications

ACTIVITIES

Student Council Representative, 2002-present
Peer Tutor, 2000-present
Orientation Leader, 2000-2002
Soccer Team, 1997-present

REFERENCES

Available upon request



The Origin of Job Interviews - The Armstrong and Miller Show - Series 2 Episode 6 Preview - BBC One

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=b56eAUCTLok>



The Hiring Interview

Structure: Stages of the Interview

- Effective interviews are well-structured interactions.
- They have a beginning, which provides an orientation to what is to come,
- a middle, when the participants get down to business
- an end, when the main points are reviewed and the participants take leave of one another.

The Hiring Interview

- **Questions: The heart of the Interview**
 - **Closed questions—highly structured questions answerable with a simple yes or no or in a few brief words**
 - **Open questions—offer the interviewee freedom with regard to the choice and scope of an answer**

The Hiring Interview

- Questions (continued)
 - Primary questions—used to introduce topics or explore a new area
 - Secondary questions—follow up primary questions

Whatever the type of question, an interviewee must maintain honesty in answering.

The Hiring Interview

Objectives: Roles and responsibilities

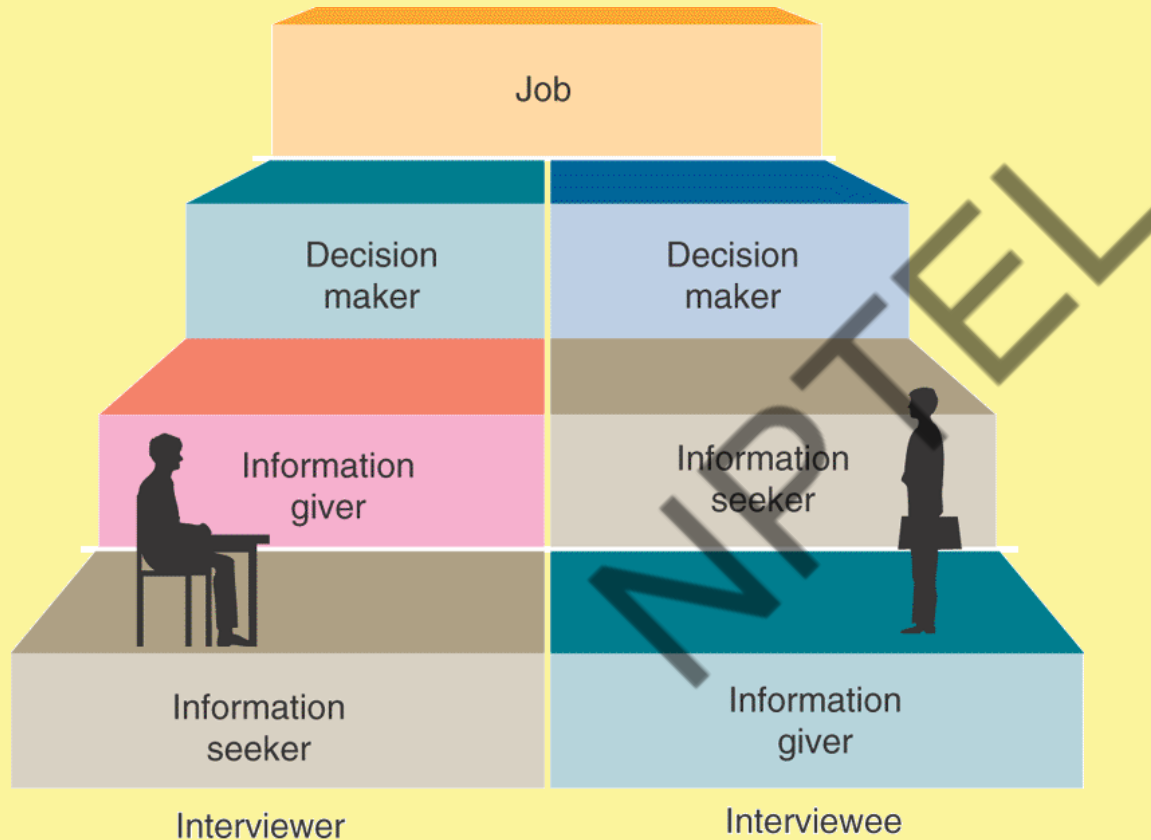
- Good interviewers and interviewees work hard during an interview, functioning simultaneously as information seekers, information givers, and decision makers.
- To be a successful interviewee requires specific preparation

The Hiring Interview

Objectives: Roles and responsibilities

- Honest self-assessment, practice in answering typical questions, and mastery of the techniques of impression management are of prime importance.
- To avoid misunderstanding, both interviewer and interviewee need to be aware of how cultural differences could affect the interview.

Responsibilities in an Interview



The Hiring Interview

- Behavioural interview—employer looks for the employee to provide specific examples of specific skills
- Case interview—interviewee is presented with a business case by the employer and asked to work through it
- Stress interview—more than one person fires questions at an interviewee

The Hiring Interview

- Impression management: Effective Interviewing
 - Job Applicant
 - Interviewer

Diversity and the Interview

- Our culture could influence how we conduct ourselves during an interview
 - There are gender and age differences in what employees seek in a job

Technology and the job search

- The Web is changing the way we find jobs
 - Job openings posted online before they appear in newspapers
 - Employers using computers to add flexibility to currently available interviewing channels

Looking at the law: Illegal questions in Interviews

- Equal Employment Opportunity Commission (EEOC) issued employment interview guidelines
 - Interviewees protected from answering questions about race, ethnicity, marital status, age, sex, disability and arrest records

Looking at the law: Illegal questions in Interviews

- Handling illegal questions
 - Object diplomatically and remind the interviewer that the question is inappropriate
 - Respond to illegal question with only information the interviewer could have legally sought from you

Increasing your effectiveness in Interviews: Guidelines

1. Be prepared
2. Practice sending and receiving messages
3. Demonstrate effective listening skills
4. Have conviction

Increasing your effectiveness in Interviews: Guidelines

5. Be flexible
6. Be observant
7. Consider the offer
8. Chart your progress

Summary

- There are six types of interviews:
 1. Information-gathering interview
 2. Appraisal interview
 3. Persuasive interview
 4. Exit interview
 5. Counseling interview
 6. Hiring interview

Summary

- Effective interviews are well-structured interactions.
- Questions are the heart of the interview and the primary means of collecting data.
- Four basic questions are asked in an interview:
 - Closed
 - Open
 - Primary
 - Secondary

Summary

- Good interviewers and interviewees work hard during an interview, functioning simultaneously as information seekers, information givers, and decision makers.

Tom Hanks "Big Job Interview Scene"

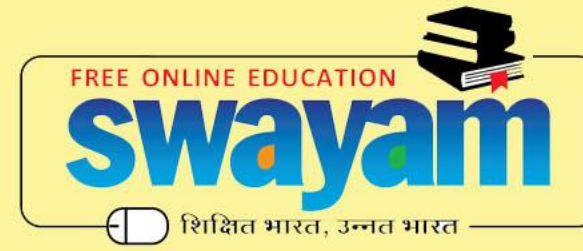
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=RsDj2fzEGdM>



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4. Understanding Human Communication – Adler & Rodman, OUP: 2003
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